

R U N

They never die, they always shrivel up. Skin sticks to their bones with hollowed cheeks and dry eyes. They somehow shrink, I've seen the biggest one of them changing from 6 feet to 5 when they lay down on the floor. Not like they have a choice, no source of food, nothing at all. Not unless they counted themselves.

I'll never understand how much blood they can seep out when knife hits skin. They only stare at me with beady eyes when it's time for them to finally rest.

Sreya Ahmed, age 13. I made a new friend only to eat them in the end.

I do not believe that it was punishment for her only, it was for both of us.

I didn't ask for this, I never wanted to do this. They put me in this brown room with a mirror showing the other side, the *real world*. They put me in here with the same canvas on the wall and a bed next to the window, carpet lush and velvet. The same texture, the same form, the same air—but it never feels the same as the other side of the mirror.

I despise it, I envy it and today I hated it even more. They keep coming here, setting their own trap in the small room. The room is cheese and I remain as a mouse-trap.

Today it was a boy, around my age when I got trapped, 17. Brown hair, brown eyes, just like the room. Simple, simple, *simple*.

Simple, just like how he'll end up in my side of the mirror. *Simple*, like how he'll shrivel up like Sreya. *Simple*, like how he will lie in his own blood once a new person claims the room.

I check the clock inside my sham room – 1:50 AM.

"I'm sorry, friend." Sreya's blood was still fresh, the only paint I had in the room, drenching my fingers.

Slow, steady steps forward. I wanted to slow the process, but it only ever took 5. I counted every time I reached the mirror.

Will he listen to me?

Will he do what he is supposed to?

Will he get out in one piece?

Sreya's ink is not wasted, I hope not, as I drag my finger across the glass. Up. Down. Left. Right. The same three letters I've drawn for the past few years.

Nabila Siddique

R U N

I hope he listens when he wakes up.

1:52

His eyes shoot open and face my pounding, freezing at first sight.

Run, run, please. I pound louder, shooting him off his phase and watching him try to bolt. Blanket wrapped around his body while it delayed his leap across the room. I pound louder for him to hurry.

1:55 on the little desk clock, I was left alone again, still pounding.

~~GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET~~
~~OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT.~~
~~GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET~~
~~OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT. GET OUT.~~

I can't see the other parts of the house but I feel it, I feel his steps on the aged wood. It creaked under his foot like it could break any moment. This house is a part of me, just something I can't see or roam around. Not unless it's 2 AM, but it is.

I can still feel the house when I'm out the other side of the reflection, his heartbeat and where he stayed in what room. His heartbeat that I could feel as if it were my own.

First floor, kitchen, his feet rooted on white tiles. His blood pulsating, in sync with the *tick-tick-tick* of the clock. No shuffles, just steady rising heartbeat.

I stand and wait in the brown room that I watch year-long, a different atmosphere with windows open with fresh air.

Windows on my side are never open.

And I bolt. My feet against the aged wood. No, I do not thump, I do not make a sound, this world cannot hear me either ways. The floor does not creak like it did for the boy, nor does it act as if it will break. I am as silent as a mime, quieter than light wind. If I could be heard, I imagine my heart beating faster than the boy's, but a monster does not have a heart.

Cold, cold, cold tiles beneath us, face to face with the brown boy. Nameless and helpless, frozen in spot with a wet bead trailing down his neck.

"What do you want?" He whispers, a knife wielding in front of me.

Nabila Siddique

I do not respond, I do not need to.

My foot forward and his foot back. It was a dance, back and forth, back and forth, until his back leans against the wall, *no*, an exit. His body smooth like water opening the door and dashing out, not one glance behind. His bare heels were flashing with soil and leaves under the moonlight.

Perhaps I was wrong, the real dance was our run.

Feet in sync, crunching the red-yellow leaves, one of us with a weapon, another bare-handed.

Crunch, crunch, crunch, the sounds were all his and his alone. Yet I am never able to make any, it's like I'm not allowed, left with weightless legs that almost float towards him.

Most days I want to quit, just stop. But I can't leave, I'll never be able to leave. Every single time, every single person before Sreya and including Sreya. They repeat in my head like a lullaby. Same pathway I chase them in, same trees marked with aged moss. We all end up with the same dance when we meet.

And I catch them every time, our little dance always ends with them falling and screaming.

They *try* to scream, I don't let them with the same hands I used on every person's neck. Different necks, different shades of purple on each individual face.

"I'm sorry," I say.

"I'm sorry," I repeat, he'll hear me now, they always hear me when they turn purple.

When the clock strikes 2:24 AM, our bodies are back in the brown room. The fake one, the one where I can't leave.

The room where I'll watch the brown boy shrivel up into skin and bones. And I'll apologize when I have to dig my knife into him. I'll keep saying sorry when I have to kill another friend.